A bounded automation pilot

Reliable request routing. Accountable human decisions.
A separate, measurable policy-assistant experiment.

Decide

Is the investment justified?

Deliver

Does the process work?

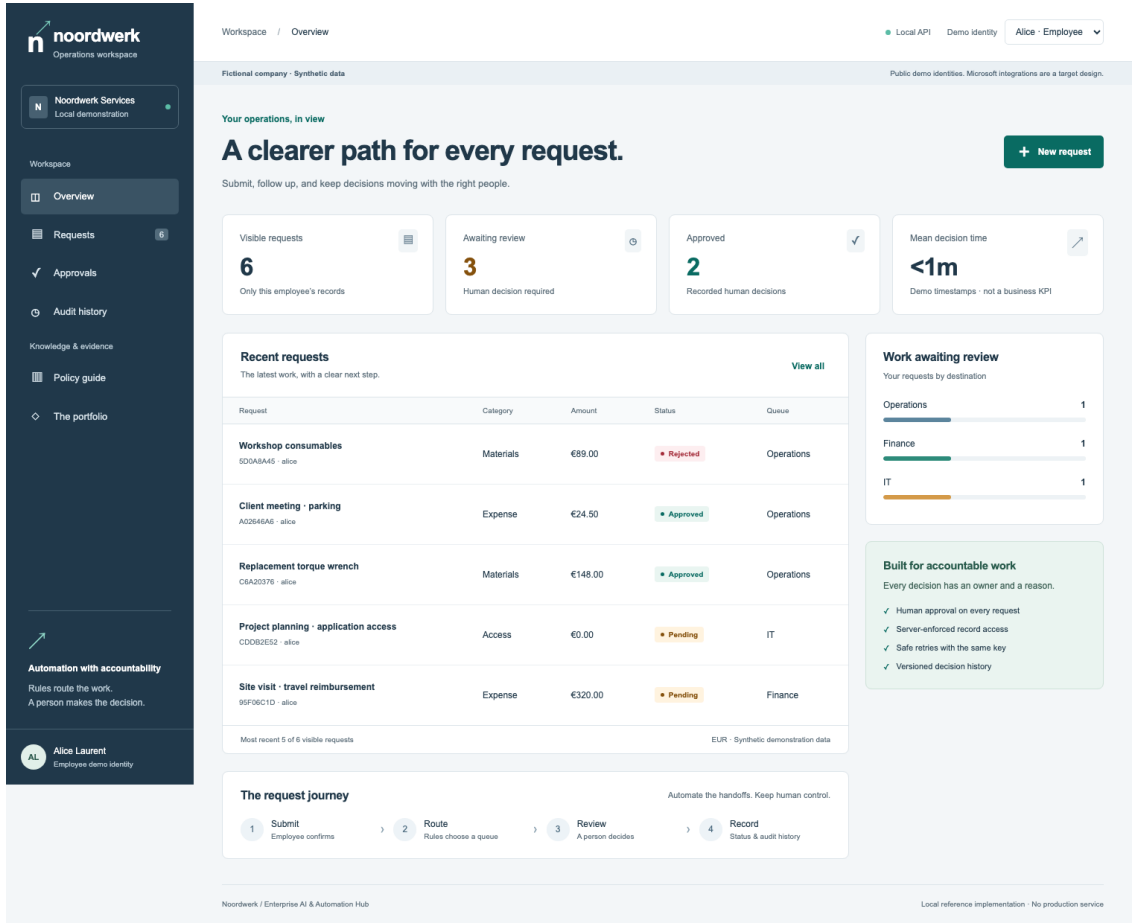
Govern

Are the boundaries proven?

Sponsor recommendation: fund discovery; gate further spend on measured evidence.

The employee-to-reviewer journey

A real local application on the existing .NET API. Microsoft tenant integration remains a target design.



Working locally

Submit

Category, amount, explicit confirmation.

Review

A separate identity records a reason.

Follow up

Status and durable decision history.

Recover

Safe retries and version conflicts.

Where the process loses time

Scenario assumptions: 140 employees, 600 requests a month. Baseline observations still need to be collected.

Current process

Email intake

Missing category or amount

→

Find an owner

Unclear queue and follow-up

→

Reconcile decisions

Approval buried in messages

Proposed process

Validated request

Employee confirms the details

→

Deterministic routing

IT / Finance / Operations

→

Human decision

Reason, version and audit event

Measure active work and approval waiting separately; workflow software cannot remove reviewer workload.

Choose the smallest useful intervention

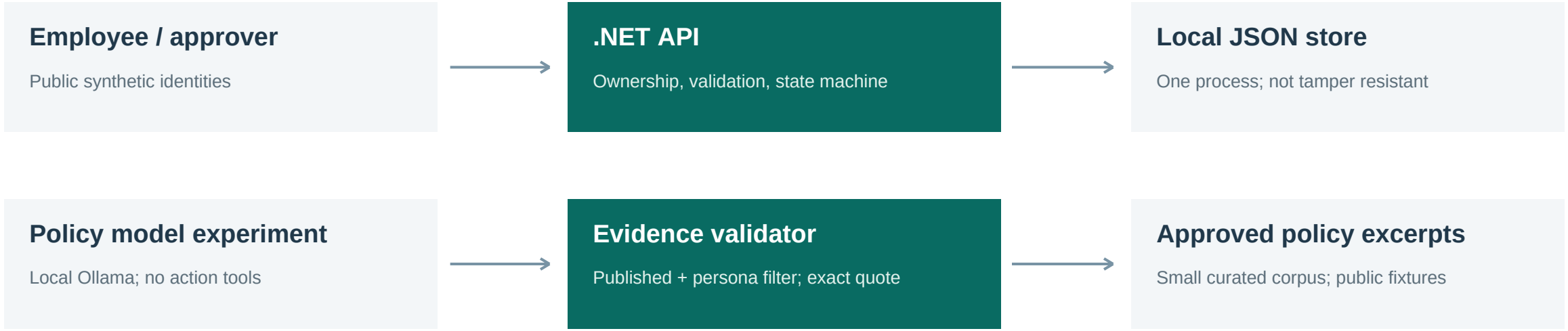
Use-case scoring guides the discussion; ownership, data permission and risk are hard gates.

Rules-only routing	High readiness / low model risk	**Pilot first**
Policy evidence assistant	Source ownership + model quality required	**Experiment**
Document extraction	Input quality and secure storage unresolved	**Defer**
Autonomous HR decisions	No owner / no data permission / high risk	**Block**

Alternative: standardise email intake and name queue owners first. Choose Power Platform only after entitlement and support review.

Architecture and trust boundaries

Solid components run locally. Microsoft products below the boundary are the deployment target, not a fabricated live integration.



Tenant gate

Entra identity + queue permissions / Power Apps + Power Automate / Dataverse + protected audit / Copilot Studio + source access / approved HTTPS ingress

Model gate FAILED: v2 answers supported questions but misses safe abstention. No action tools.

The economics do not justify immediate rollout

Capacity is an assumption. Only 50% of released capacity is treated as economically realised value.

EUR -7,695

Year-one net, including adoption ramp

25 months

First non-negative cumulative month

EUR 12,000

Implementation allowance

EUR 350 / month

Licensing, AI, hosting and support

42 hours / month

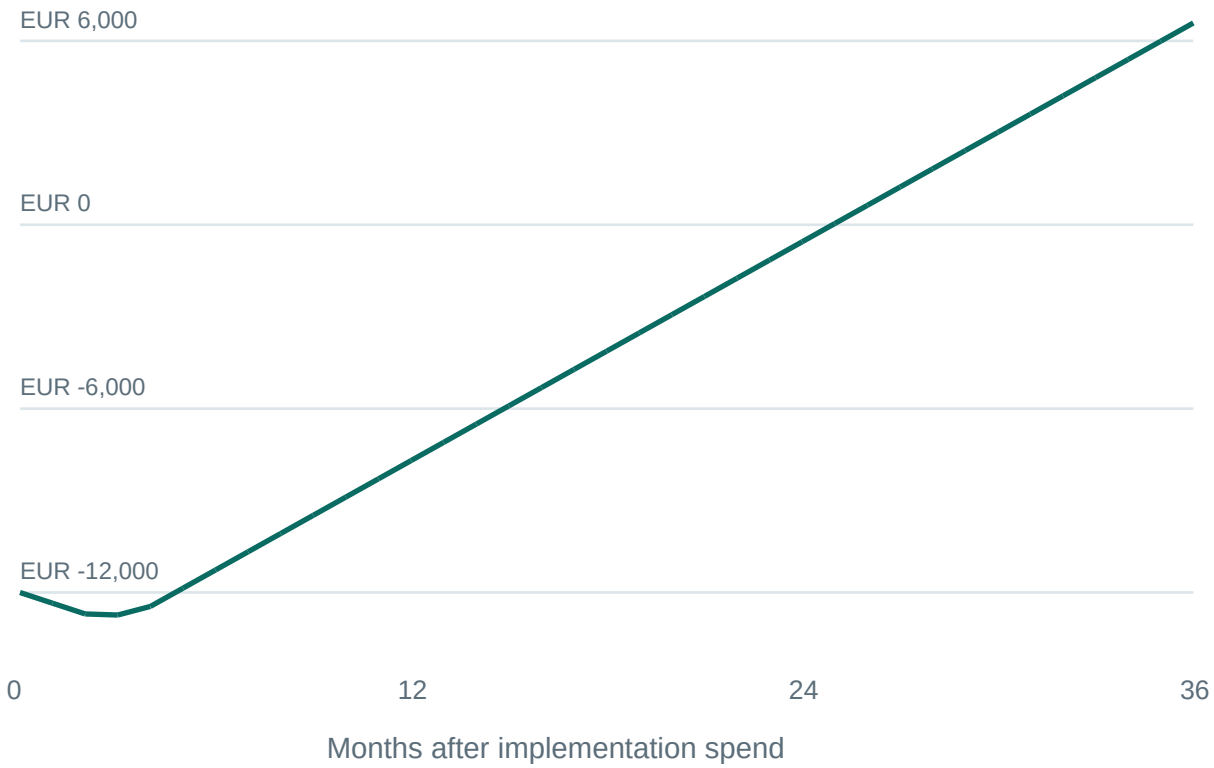
Capacity at 60% steady adoption

Ramp assumption: no benefits in months 1-2; adoption 20% in month 3, 40% in month 4, then 60%. Recurring cost begins in month 1.

Source: output/investment-case.json. Original immediate-benefit model: EUR -4,860 in year one and 20.17-month payback. No vendor quotes or measured customer savings.

Cash flow and sensitivity

A useful business case must make it easy to reject an unfavourable investment.



Year-one net by adoption and cost

Adoption	EUR 200	EUR 350	EUR 600
30%	-8,730	-10,530	-13,530
60%	-3,060	-4,860	-7,860
90%	2,610	810	-2,190

Right: steady-state scenarios without ramp. Base first-year break-even adoption is 85.71%. All amounts are synthetic EUR.

Governance determines whether the pilot can proceed

Controls implemented in a public local demo are not a substitute for tenant identity and operational acceptance.

Access	**IT**	Real employee and reviewer logins; negative access tests.
Policy quality	**Finance / IT**	Publish and revoke sources; independently review model relevance.
Consequential actions	**Process owner**	No model approval authority; human reason and current version.
Release and recovery	**Platform owner**	Managed Test import, connection ownership and recovery drill.
Value and adoption	**Sponsor / Change**	Measure time, rework, usage and cost; stop if value is absent.

Seven gated delivery phases

Decision sequence, not a six-week promise. Tenant access, reviewers and confirmed entitlements remain dependencies.

Phase	Work / evidence	Exit decision
0 Discovery	Baseline, rights and licensing	Signed problem, owner and budget
1 Process validation	AS-IS / TO-BE rules and exceptions	Staff and Finance agree the process
2 Controlled prototype	Synthetic workflow and frozen model tests	Reproducible; model status disclosed
3 Limited pilot	Five users; real identity and recovery	IT accepts access and recovery tests
4 Independent evaluation	Held-out tasks, relevance, time and cost	Independent quality and value review
5 Go / no-go	Compare measured value, risk and cap	Scale, simplify, defer or stop
6 Conditional rollout	Small cohorts, training and rollback	Expand only while thresholds hold

Source: docs/requirements-and-roadmap.md. Tenant pilot and rollout have not been executed. Handover requires a named owner and deputy, incident response and a tested restore procedure.

Approve the learning, then earn the rollout

A bounded pilot is valuable only if it can lead to a well-supported stop decision.

Confirm the problem

Measure active handling time, approval delay and incomplete submissions.

Set the spending limit

Separate discovery, platform, support and model consumption allowances.

Require evidence at each gate

No rollout without accepted security, model quality and a refreshed business case.

Companion evidence: Hub source + tests / Agent model reports / Playbook inputs + monthly cash flow

Prepared by Philippe Godfroy. Fictional consulting exercise; not a real engagement or procurement recommendation.